they had a winner on their hands. Four months before its release, they took a bold decision: to split the film into two parts so that the story would not be compromised. "Aditya and I knew it would be all or nothing," says Deshpande. "Either the second part would be toilet paper, something we wouldn't sell to anybody and be the only ones to see, or the film would be extremely successful."

Two years on, their gamble having paid off, Deshpande and the Dhars are having the last laugh. The Dhurandhar duology has set new benchmarks for the domestic box office, with the Hindi version collectively amassing over $187 million (Rs 1,790-plus crore), and an additional haul of $45 million from the United States (see *Dhurandharmania*). The films' worldwide total has surpassed $320 million (Rs 3,000 crore). Not just India, even Pakistan, the film's narrative punching bag, couldn't help but be curious, with reports of nearly 20 million illegal downloads of Part 1 and the film trending at #1 on Netflix for weeks.

PATRIOTISM MEETS STYLE

Part of the reason the *Dhurandhar* duology has been embraced with such gusto by audiences worldwide is that "all of us want victims of terror attacks to be avenged and for justice to prevail", says Akkshay Rathie, a film exhibitor and distributor. Telling the story of an Indian spy, Hamza, played by Ranveer Singh, the duology tracks his initiation into the intelligence ecosystem and how he infiltrates the terror infrastructure in Pakistan. "*Dhurandhar* is every Indian's fantasy coming true on celluloid," adds Rathie. The film projects the rise of an assertive India, or as Hamza and Indian intelligence chief Ajay Sanyal (R. Madhavan) say, "*Yeh naya Hindustan hai. Ghar mein ghusega bhi, aur maarega bhi* (This is a new India, it will force its way into your house, and kill you too)."

However, according to Shailesh Kapoor, founder and CEO of Ormax Media, a firm that tracks India's media and entertainment industries, the films' success cannot be attributed solely to their ability to stoke nationalist sentiment. "[It's unlike] *The Kashmir Files* and *The Kerala Story* because they were backed by political and religious groups... [*Dhurandhar*'s popularity] is more organic than orchestrated," he says. Unlike the overly glamourised spy universe (*War*, *Pathaan* and *Tiger Zinda Hai*) of Yash Raj Films, the shrewdness and sacrifice of Dhar's R&AW operatives are expressed in more understated tones. Yes, Part 1 is an espionage thriller, but it's also a gangster-led crime drama. It has adrenaline-pumping action and well-etched, compelling characters, like the crooked politician Jameel Jamali played with delightful precision by Rakesh Bedi. Clips from the 26/11 Mumbai terror attacks are seamlessly woven into the



GETTY IMAGES

MEN OF THE MOMENT
Ranveer Singh and director Aditya Dhar; right, Sanjay Dutt as Pakistani cop Chaudhary Aslam



"I LIKED THE FACT THAT *DHURANDHAR*'S TAKE ON PATRIOTISM WAS THROUGH A GANGSTER-STYLE TREATMENT, WITHOUT IT BEING IN YOUR FACE, AND WAS STILL MORE MOVING THAN MOST PATRIOTIC FILMS"

JYOTI DESHPANDE
President, Jio Studios (Media & Content Business RIL)